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The Last Fortress: How the NNP Held St. George North West

The NNP's only surviving seat held because the party planned a succession, chose early and stayed united. But the fortress is shrinking: fewer voters, a lost village, and a vote that has fallen at every election since 2018.

BY GREG HOSTEN ST. GEORGE NORTH WEST, GRENADA

ST. GEORGE NORTH WEST, GRENADA—In an election that swept away 14 of its 15 seats, the New National Party kept exactly one: St. George North West, the constituency Dr. Keith Mitchell represented from December 1984 until Parliament was dissolved this year. His successor, Dr. Adrian Joseph, took 2,052 votes on 5 November to 810 for the NDC's Nigel DeGale and 69 for Jonathan La Crette of the People's National Party. A majority of 1,242 in a national rout is no small thing.

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> GREG HOSTEN

But the lesson of St. George North West is not that the seat is safe. It is that the NNP did here, almost step for step, what it failed to do everywhere else, and that even here the ground is moving under its feet. The party held the fortress. It did not grow it.

FORTY-TWO YEARS OF ONE MAN

Dr. Mitchell was first elected for St. George North West in December 1984 and held it at every election that followed. He led the NNP from 1989, served as prime minister for nearly 23 years across two spells, and remained the seat's member after the party lost government in 2022. He was born in Brizan, one of the villages he represented.

His margins tell the story of a personal fortress. In 2018 he beat the NDC's Ali Dowden by 2,546 votes to 406, more than 86 per cent of the two-party vote. In 2022, the year his party lost power, he still took 2,211 votes against 773 for the NDC's Jonathan La Crette, about 74 per cent. Turnout that year was 66 per cent of an electorate of 4,534.

A SUCCESSION PLANNED IN JANUARY

Dr. Mitchell, then 79, announced his retirement at a party forum on 22 January 2026 and named his successor the same night: Dr. Adrian Joseph, the acting Clerk of Parliament, a diplomat and former Chief of Protocol. Within days the branch formally endorsed Dr. Joseph as caretaker.

That gave the newcomer about ten months before polling day, with the outgoing member's public endorsement and a united branch behind him. Nobody in the seat had to wonder who the party's candidate was. Compare that with the Town of St. George, where the NNP's branch executive resigned and a former minister took his base to a new party, or St. George South, where the NNP has run four different candidates in four elections.

THE NDC CHOSE LATE, AND DIVIDED

The NDC's path ran the other way. Prime Minister Dickon Mitchell dismissed Mr. La Crette from Cabinet at the end of July 2024 and had his Senate appointment revoked. By October 2024 Mr. La Crette had resigned from the NDC, and on 1 June 2025 he launched the People's National Party, announcing that he would contest St. George North West under its banner.

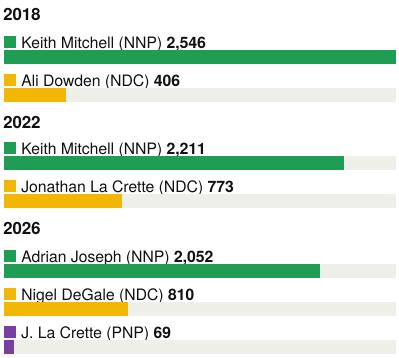
Congress was left without a candidate for most of the term. By September 2026 the seat was one of three for which it still had no standard-bearer. That month retired school principal Nigel DeGale won the nomination and said he could deliver the seat for the first time since 1984. He had roughly eight weeks to do it.

LOYALTY, NOT MOMENTUM

Dr. Joseph's 2,052 votes were 71.7 per cent of the vote for the two main parties, in an election where the NNP drew 37.7 per cent nationally. The seat ran 34 points ahead of the party, up from 26 points in 2022, because the party has fallen much faster than its

2018 VS 2022 VS 2026

Votes by candidate, in party colours



1,242 votes
NNP winning margin in 2026

BY THE NUMBERS

14 of 15
Polling divisions won by the NNP

59.2%
Turnout, the second-lowest of all 15 seats

–494
Fall in the NNP vote since 2018

1 of 15
Seats the NNP kept nationally

fortress.

The handover itself worked. Between 2022 and 2026 the NNP's two-party share here fell by only 2.4 points, against 10.3 points nationally. The voters who had backed Dr. Mitchell for four decades largely transferred to the man he chose. That is the strongest evidence in the whole series that early, public succession planning protects a seat.

Yet the fortress is shrinking. The NNP's vote here has fallen at every election, from 2,546 in 2018 to 2,211 in 2022 and 2,052 in 2026, a loss of 494 votes in eight years. The NDC's vote has doubled over the same period, from 406 to 810. The seat is still safe. It is less safe than it was.

THE VILLAGE THE NNP LOST

The polling-division results show where the walls are thinnest. The NNP carried 14 of the 15 divisions. Its strongholds are Brizan, where it took 77.9 per cent of the two-party vote across two divisions, Happy Hill with 78.8 per cent across three, and Grand Mal with 76.2 per cent. In one Grand Mal division the NNP took 174 votes to the NDC's 34.

The exception is Willis. At the Willis Community Centre the NDC won by 142 votes to 125, the only division in the constituency the NNP failed to carry. Nearby Grenville Vale, the smallest division with 103 voters, gave the NNP just 55 per cent. These are the cracks an opponent will widen over the next four years, and they are where a sitting member must be seen first.

THE 2,027 WHO STAYED HOME

The quietest number in St. George North West is the most worrying. Turnout fell from 66.1 per cent in 2022 to 59.2 per cent this year, the second-lowest of all 15 constituencies after St. George South. The register grew by 432 names, yet 56 fewer ballots were cast. This year 2,027 registered voters did not vote.

Measured against the whole electorate, the NNP's position has slipped sharply. In 2022 Dr. Mitchell won the votes of 48.8 per cent of every registered voter in the seat. In 2026 Dr. Joseph won 41.3 per cent. A fortress defended by fewer and fewer people is not a fortress for long.

THE BREAKAWAY THAT BARELY REGISTERED

Mr. La Crette's candidacy is a useful test of personal votes. In 2022, as the NDC candidate, he won 773 votes. Standing for his own party in 2026, he won 69. The NDC's vote barely moved. Nearly all of his 2022 support belonged to the party, not to him.

Contrast that with the Town of St. George, where Peter David took 730 votes for his Democratic People's Movement after leaving the NNP, and handed the seat to the NDC by three votes. The difference is that Mr. David had spent years building a personal base in the Town, including a term as its MP. A breakaway candidate is dangerous only when the base walks out with him. Here it did not.

ONE SEAT IS NOT A PARTY

The NNP now holds one seat in fifteen, and that seat is held by a man who has never faced the voters before. Its parliamentary presence rests on a constituency whose loyalty was built by someone who has left the ballot. Whether that loyalty becomes Dr. Joseph's own will depend on what he does between now and the next election.

There is a deeper risk for the party. A seat that wins this comfortably can become an excuse not to change. The NNP's national share of the two-party vote has fallen from 48.0 per cent in 2022 to 37.7 per cent in 2026. One safe seat cannot hide that, and should not be allowed to.

WHAT CAN BE DONE: A FOUR-YEAR PLAN TO HOLD AND GROW

St. George North West does not need rescuing. It needs a sitting member who turns an inherited majority into a personal one, and a party that uses its only seat as a base for the rest of St. George.

Year one, 2027: open a permanent constituency office and publish regular surgery hours, so that Dr. Joseph is known by his own service and not only by Dr. Mitchell's endorsement. Start in Willis and Grenville Vale, where the NNP is weakest, before Brizan and Happy Hill, where it is strongest. Build a household list of the 2,027 who stayed home.

Year two, 2028: run a turnout programme aimed at young and first-time voters, whose names are swelling the register while the number of ballots falls. Register new voters every month, not every election. Give each of the 15 polling divisions its own captain, with a target for contacts each quarter.

Year three, 2029: make the seat the NNP's training ground for St. George. Send volunteers from Brizan, Happy Hill and Grand Mal to help rebuild the branches in the Town of St. George and St. George North East, where the party's vote collapsed. A fortress that does not supply the rest of the army is only a refuge.

Year four, 2030: set targets that measure growth, not survival. Win back Willis. Lift turnout back above 66 per cent. Push the NNP vote back above the 2,211 Dr. Mitchell won in 2022. If those three things happen, the seat will be safer at the next election than it was at this one, which has not been true since 2018.

THE LESSON FOR EVERY NNP SEAT

Here the party chose early, the old member handed over in public, the branch stayed united, and the split hurt the other side. In the Town of St. George every one of those went the wrong way, and the NNP lost the capital by three votes.

The method is not a secret. It was tried in one constituency in 2026 and it worked in the worst national result in the party's history. The question for 2030/31 is whether the NNP will apply it in the other fourteen, starting now.

THE ARITHMETIC OF ST. GEORGE NORTH WEST

Measure	2018	2022	2026
NNP votes	2,546	2,211	2,052
NDC votes	406	773	810
Breakaway candidate (PNP)			69
NNP share of two-party vote	86.2%	74.1%	71.7%
NNP two-party share nationally		48.0%	37.7%
Winning margin	NNP +2,140	NNP +1,438	NNP +1,242
Registered voters		4,534	4,966
Turnout		66.1%	59.2% (2nd lowest of 15)
Registered voters who did not vote		1,539	2,027
NNP votes as a share of all registered voters		48.8%	41.3%
Polling divisions won by the NNP			14 of 15

Two-party figures exclude minor candidates. 2026 figures are provisional results from the Parliamentary Elections Office, all 15 polling divisions verified.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR 2030/31

1. Choose early: ten months of caretaking beat eight weeks of campaigning.
2. Hand over in public: a trusted incumbent's endorsement transfers loyalty.
3. Holding is not growing: the NNP vote here has fallen at every election since 2018.
4. Fix the weak spots first: Willis and Grenville Vale before the strongholds.
5. Chase the 2,027 non-voters: turnout fell seven points in four years.
6. Turn an inherited majority into a personal one through visible service.
7. Use safe seats to train volunteers for the seats that were lost.
8. A breakaway hurts only when the base walks out with the candidate.

Sources: Parliamentary Elections Office live results, live.elections.gd (2026, provisional; polling divisions read 9 Nov 2026); NOW Grenada (PNP launch and 2022 results, 3 Jun 2025; La Crette, 23 Jun 2025; 2026 candidate list); The New Today (NDC candidate, 12 Sep 2026); Jamaica Observer / CMC (Mitchell retirement, 23 Jan 2026); Caribbean National Weekly (La Crette resignation and PNP launch; farewell sitting, 2026); Wikipedia (Keith Mitchell; 2022 general election); Searchlight (2018 results). Analytics computed by the author from the published counts. Analysis by Greg Hosten, Vol. 2 of a weekly constituency series. Written in the style of a newspaper report; not a publication of any news organisation.